

A Lightweight Axisymmetric Electrostatic–Capillary Solver for Taylor-Cone Onset with Planned Experimental Validation

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Abstract

Electrospray and colloid thrusters rely on the formation of a Taylor cone, an electrohydrodynamic interface where electric Maxwell stress balances capillary stress. High-fidelity electrospray modeling can require expensive multiphysics software, dense meshes, and substantial computation, creating a barrier for early-stage design and student research. This project develops a lightweight, open-source, two-dimensional axisymmetric Python solver for onset-level Taylor-cone modeling on consumer hardware. The solver assembles sparse finite-difference Laplace/Poisson electrostatic systems, reconstructs electric fields, evaluates Maxwell and capillary pressure on a candidate interface, computes a Young–Laplace–Maxwell residual, and optionally includes effective Gaussian or threshold-activated space-charge shielding closures. Preliminary numerical validation demonstrates recovery of the classical Taylor half-angle benchmark, manufactured Poisson convergence, voltage scaling consistency, residual sanity checks, and a passing automated test suite. The planned experimental validation will image supervised Taylor-cone formation, extract cone profiles and half-angles using computer vision, and compare measured profiles and onset-voltage trends against solver predictions using angle error, profile RMSE, and voltage-error metrics. The project is intentionally framed as a reduced-order onset model, not a full CFD, cone-jet breakup, or complete thruster-performance simulator. Its goal is to evaluate how accurately a transparent sparse solver can capture key Taylor-cone observables while remaining accessible to students and small laboratories.

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1 Introduction

Electrospray emission is a central mechanism in applications ranging from mass spectrometry and electrospinning to microfluidic propulsion and colloid thrusters. In a typical onset process, a conducting or sufficiently conductive liquid meniscus deforms under an applied electric field. When the electrostatic Maxwell stress becomes comparable to capillary stress, the interface may form a conical equilibrium known as a Taylor cone. Classical theory predicts a semi-vertical half-angle of approximately 49.3° in the ideal conducting, charge-free limit [1].

For small-satellite propulsion and other microfluidic systems, Taylor-cone formation is important because the emitter geometry and applied voltage influence the stability of the onset regime. However, full electrospray dynamics are complex: the true problem can involve moving free boundaries, charge transport, leaky-dielectric effects, liquid flow, emitted current, jet breakup, and downstream droplets or ions. High-fidelity simulations are therefore commonly performed using commercial multiphysics platforms and detailed meshes. Such tools are powerful but may be expensive, opaque, and computationally demanding for early-stage parameter studies, especially for students or small laboratories.

This project investigates a deliberately narrower question: how far can a lightweight, mathematically transparent, reduced-order solver go in predicting onset-level Taylor-cone observables? Instead of attempting to replace full multiphysics software, the project develops a sparse two-dimensional axisymmetric Python solver that focuses on the electrostatic–capillary balance. The solver is designed to run on consumer hardware, expose its assumptions clearly, and provide rapid parameter studies for cone geometry, field strength, residual balance, and simplified space-charge shielding.

The project has three validation layers. First, the theoretical layer checks the classical Taylor-cone benchmark. Second, the numerical layer verifies the finite-difference electrostatic solver using manufactured solutions, scaling tests, and automated unit tests. Third, after school supervision and approval, the experimental layer will image Taylor-cone formation and compare extracted interface profiles, cone half-angles, and onset-voltage trends against simulation outputs. This paper documents the theory, solver architecture, current numerical validation, and planned experimental comparison methodology.

2 Literature Review

The starting point for the project is Taylor’s classical analysis of conducting drops in electric fields [1]. In the ideal electrostatic limit, the exterior potential satisfies Laplace’s equation and the conical conducting boundary imposes a Legendre-function condition. Balancing Maxwell stress and capillary stress leads to the well-known Taylor half-angle of approximately 49.3° . This result is a benchmark rather than a novelty of the present work.

Subsequent studies and reviews show that real electrospray operation extends beyond the static Taylor-cone equilibrium. Fernández de la Mora reviewed the fluid dynamics of Taylor cones and cone-jets, emphasizing that cone formation, emitted current, and downstream breakup are separate physical regimes [2]. Melcher and Taylor developed broader electrohydrodynamic stress-balance concepts at fluid interfaces [3], while Saville reviewed the Taylor–Melcher leaky-dielectric model, which includes finite conductivity, surface charge, and tangential electric stresses [4]. Gañán-Calvo connected Taylor-type electrostatic solutions to cone-jet scaling laws [5], and Fernández de la Mora and Loscertales studied current emitted by highly conducting Taylor cones [6]. Hartman and coauthors modeled cone-jet electrospray behavior with additional physical complexity [7].

These studies motivate two important boundaries for the present project. First, the solver should reproduce the classical Taylor limit in the appropriate charge-free conducting case. Second, the solver should not overclaim full electrospray prediction. The present model does not solve transient Navier–Stokes flow, full Taylor–Melcher surface charge conservation, droplet breakup, or plume physics. Instead, it implements a reduced-order axisymmetric electrostatic–capillary model with effective Poisson space-charge closures. The intended contribution is accessibility and transparency: a sparse Python implementation that can be inspected, tested, and run on consumer hardware for onset-level parameter studies.

3 Research Question and Hypothesis

3.1 Research Question

The central research question is:

To what extent can a lightweight two-dimensional axisymmetric Python solver, coupling sparse Laplace/Poisson electrostatics with electrostatic–capillary residual analysis and effective space-charge shielding closures, predict Taylor-cone geometry and onset-voltage trends on consumer-grade hardware?

3.2 Hypothesis

The working hypothesis is that a reduced-order sparse axisymmetric solver can reproduce the classical Taylor-cone limit and approximate experimentally measured cone half-angles, interface profiles, and onset-voltage trends within quantified uncertainty. The expected dominant error sources are finite-grid boundary representation, simplified effective space-charge closures, and physical effects not included in the static model, such as liquid flow, current transport, and full leaky-dielectric dynamics.

3.3 Scope

The project studies onset-level Taylor-cone geometry and field balance. It does not aim to simulate the full downstream cone-jet, droplet breakup, emission-current law, plume dynamics, or complete thruster performance. This limited scope is intentional: the purpose is to test whether a transparent lightweight model captures key observables before using more complex simulations.

4 Theoretical Model and Derivations

This section gives the mathematical foundation of the solver. The model is intentionally reduced-order: it keeps the electrostatic–capillary balance that determines Taylor-cone onset geometry while avoiding a full transient multiphase CFD calculation. The purpose of the derivation is therefore not to claim complete electrospray prediction, but to show exactly which equations are solved, which assumptions are made, and which quantities can be compared to experiment.

4.1 Geometry, Coordinates, and Main Assumptions

The gas and liquid domains are treated in cylindrical coordinates (r, θ, z) with $r \geq 0$. The first model assumes axisymmetry, so all fields are independent of θ . The electric potential is $\phi(r, z)$ and

the electric field is

$$\mathbf{E} = -\nabla\phi. \quad (1)$$

In cylindrical coordinates under axisymmetry,

$$\mathbf{E} = E_r \mathbf{e}_r + E_z \mathbf{e}_z, \quad E_r = -\frac{\partial\phi}{\partial r}, \quad E_z = -\frac{\partial\phi}{\partial z}. \quad (2)$$

The liquid–gas interface is represented as a graph

$$r = R(z), \quad (3)$$

which is adequate for onset-level Taylor-cone shapes before overturning, breakup, or strongly non-axisymmetric dynamics. The conducting-liquid approximation treats the liquid as an equipotential boundary in the first model. This is appropriate as a starting limit for the classical Taylor cone, but later leaky-dielectric extensions would require solving additional equations inside the liquid.

4.2 Axisymmetric Laplace and Poisson Equations

Electrostatics obeys Gauss’s law,

$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{D} = \rho_e, \quad (4)$$

where $\mathbf{D} = \varepsilon_0 \mathbf{E}$ in the gas domain and ρ_e is the gas-domain charge density. Since $\mathbf{E} = -\nabla\phi$,

$$\nabla \cdot (-\varepsilon_0 \nabla\phi) = \rho_e. \quad (5)$$

For constant gas permittivity, this becomes Poisson’s equation,

$$\nabla^2\phi = -\frac{\rho_e}{\varepsilon_0}. \quad (6)$$

The charge-free case $\rho_e = 0$ reduces to Laplace’s equation,

$$\nabla^2\phi = 0. \quad (7)$$

For an axisymmetric scalar field, the Laplacian is

$$\nabla^2\phi = \frac{1}{r} \frac{\partial}{\partial r} \left(r \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial r} \right) + \frac{\partial^2\phi}{\partial z^2}. \quad (8)$$

Thus the actual PDE solved by the numerical core is

$$\frac{1}{r} \frac{\partial}{\partial r} \left(r \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial r} \right) + \frac{\partial^2\phi}{\partial z^2} = -\frac{\rho_e(r, z)}{\varepsilon_0}. \quad (9)$$

4.3 Boundary Conditions

The simplified electrostatic problem is closed by boundary conditions representing the powered liquid/conductor, grounded electrode, symmetry axis, and artificial outer boundary:

$$\phi = V_0 \quad \text{on powered conductor or ideal liquid surface,} \quad (10)$$

$$\phi = 0 \quad \text{on grounded extractor electrode,} \quad (11)$$

$$\frac{\partial\phi}{\partial r} = 0 \quad \text{on the axis } r = 0, \quad (12)$$

$$\phi = \phi_\infty \quad \text{or} \quad \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial n} = 0 \quad \text{on far computational boundaries.} \quad (13)$$

The axis condition is not optional: it is required because the potential must remain finite and smooth as $r \rightarrow 0$. Far-boundary conditions are numerical approximations, so their effect should be checked by moving the boundary outward or comparing alternative boundary choices.

4.4 Finite-Difference Discretization

Let the grid nodes be

$$r_i = i\Delta r, \quad z_j = z_{\min} + j\Delta z, \quad (14)$$

where $i = 0, \dots, n_r - 1$ and $j = 0, \dots, n_z - 1$. Denote $\phi_{i,j} \approx \phi(r_i, z_j)$. Expanding Eq. (8),

$$\nabla^2 \phi = \frac{\partial^2 \phi}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r} \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial^2 \phi}{\partial z^2}. \quad (15)$$

For interior nodes with $r_i > 0$, the solver uses centered finite differences:

$$\frac{\partial^2 \phi}{\partial r^2} \approx \frac{\phi_{i+1,j} - 2\phi_{i,j} + \phi_{i-1,j}}{\Delta r^2}, \quad (16)$$

$$\frac{\partial \phi}{\partial r} \approx \frac{\phi_{i+1,j} - \phi_{i-1,j}}{2\Delta r}, \quad (17)$$

$$\frac{\partial^2 \phi}{\partial z^2} \approx \frac{\phi_{i,j+1} - 2\phi_{i,j} + \phi_{i,j-1}}{\Delta z^2}. \quad (18)$$

Therefore the discrete operator at $r_i > 0$ is

$$(\nabla_h^2 \phi)_{i,j} = \frac{\phi_{i+1,j} - 2\phi_{i,j} + \phi_{i-1,j}}{\Delta r^2} + \frac{1}{r_i} \frac{\phi_{i+1,j} - \phi_{i-1,j}}{2\Delta r} + \frac{\phi_{i,j+1} - 2\phi_{i,j} + \phi_{i,j-1}}{\Delta z^2}. \quad (19)$$

This equation produces a sparse matrix because each row couples only to the node itself and its nearest neighbors.

At the axis $r = 0$, Eq. (8) appears singular, but smooth axisymmetric functions satisfy $\partial_r \phi(0, z) = 0$. Using the limiting identity

$$\lim_{r \rightarrow 0} \left(\frac{\partial^2 \phi}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r} \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial r} \right) = 2 \frac{\partial^2 \phi}{\partial r^2} \Big|_{r=0}. \quad (20)$$

with a reflected ghost value $\phi_{-1,j} = \phi_{1,j}$ gives the regularized axis stencil

$$(\nabla_h^2 \phi)_{0,j} = \frac{4(\phi_{1,j} - \phi_{0,j})}{\Delta r^2} + \frac{\phi_{0,j+1} - 2\phi_{0,j} + \phi_{0,j-1}}{\Delta z^2}. \quad (21)$$

This stencil is one of the key numerical details tested by the solver.

4.5 Classical Taylor-Cone Derivation

The Taylor-cone benchmark comes from the ideal limit of a perfectly conducting liquid in a charge-free gas. Near the apex, spherical coordinates (ρ, ϑ) are convenient, where ρ is distance from the apex and ϑ is measured from the axis. Axisymmetric Laplace's equation is

$$\frac{1}{\rho^2} \frac{\partial}{\partial \rho} \left(\rho^2 \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial \rho} \right) + \frac{1}{\rho^2 \sin \vartheta} \frac{\partial}{\partial \vartheta} \left(\sin \vartheta \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial \vartheta} \right) = 0. \quad (22)$$

Seek separated solutions of the form

$$\phi(\rho, \vartheta) = A\rho^\nu F(\vartheta). \quad (23)$$

Substitution gives the angular equation

$$\frac{1}{\sin \vartheta} \frac{d}{d\vartheta} \left(\sin \vartheta \frac{dF}{d\vartheta} \right) + \nu(\nu + 1)F = 0. \quad (24)$$

With $\mu = \cos \vartheta$, this becomes Legendre's equation,

$$\frac{d}{d\mu} \left[(1 - \mu^2) \frac{dF}{d\mu} \right] + \nu(\nu + 1)F = 0, \quad (25)$$

so the regular axisymmetric solution is

$$F(\vartheta) = P_\nu(\cos \vartheta). \quad (26)$$

Thus

$$\phi(\rho, \vartheta) = A\rho^\nu P_\nu(\cos \vartheta). \quad (27)$$

The electric field magnitude scales as

$$E \sim |\nabla \phi| \sim \rho^{\nu-1}. \quad (28)$$

Maxwell pressure therefore scales as

$$p_E \sim \varepsilon_0 E^2 \sim \rho^{2\nu-2}. \quad (29)$$

For a cone, the characteristic capillary pressure scales as

$$p_\gamma \sim \frac{\gamma}{\rho}. \quad (30)$$

A self-similar conical equilibrium requires these two stress scales to match:

$$2\nu - 2 = -1. \quad (31)$$

Therefore

$$\nu = \frac{1}{2}. \quad (32)$$

The potential near a Taylor cone must consequently scale as

$$\phi(\rho, \vartheta) = A\rho^{1/2} P_{1/2}(\cos \vartheta). \quad (33)$$

A perfect conductor is an equipotential. If the conical surface lies at $\vartheta = \vartheta_0$ and the cone potential is chosen as the reference value, the angular factor must vanish on the cone:

$$P_{1/2}(\cos \vartheta_0) = 0. \quad (34)$$

The physically relevant root is

$$\vartheta_0 \approx 130.7^\circ. \quad (35)$$

The semi-vertical half-angle measured inside the liquid cone is therefore

$$\alpha_T = 180^\circ - \vartheta_0 \approx 49.3^\circ. \quad (36)$$

This is the central analytical benchmark used by the code. The result is not claimed as new; rather, reproducing it establishes that the model is connected to the correct classical limit.

4.6 Apex Singularity and Physical Regularization

Because $\nu = 1/2$, the ideal Taylor electric field behaves as

$$E \sim \rho^{-1/2}. \quad (37)$$

Thus the ideal mathematical solution predicts

$$E \rightarrow \infty \quad \text{as} \quad \rho \rightarrow 0. \quad (38)$$

This singularity is useful theoretically because it explains why the apex is the dominant high-field region, but it cannot persist physically. Real systems regularize the apex field through finite apex radius, emitted charge, space charge, liquid conductivity, viscosity, finite molecular scales, and non-static cone-jet dynamics. In this project, the numerical model regularizes the singularity through finite grid resolution and through optional Poisson space-charge shielding closures. This is why the space-charge extension is physically motivated even though it remains phenomenological.

4.7 Maxwell Stress and Electric Pressure

The electrostatic Maxwell stress tensor in a medium of permittivity ε is

$$\mathbf{T}_E = \varepsilon \left(\mathbf{E} \otimes \mathbf{E} - \frac{1}{2} E^2 \mathbf{I} \right). \quad (39)$$

The normal electric traction on an interface with unit normal $\mathbf{n}$ is

$$\mathbf{n} \cdot \mathbf{T}_E \mathbf{n} = \varepsilon \left[(\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{n})^2 - \frac{1}{2} E^2 \right]. \quad (40)$$

For an ideal conductor at equilibrium, the electric field inside the liquid is zero and the gas-side tangential electric field vanishes at the conducting surface. Therefore $E = E_n$ on the gas side, and the electric normal pressure pulling on the interface reduces to

$$p_E = \frac{\varepsilon_0}{2} E_n^2. \quad (41)$$

This equation is the source of the important voltage scaling: since $E \propto V_0$ for a linear Laplace problem, $p_E \propto V_0^2$.

4.8 Interface Normal and Curvature

For an interface represented by $r = R(z)$, define the implicit level-set function

$$F(r, z) = r - R(z). \quad (42)$$

A unit normal pointing toward increasing r is

$$\mathbf{n} = \frac{\nabla F}{|\nabla F|} = \frac{(1, -R_z)}{\sqrt{1 + R_z^2}}. \quad (43)$$

The normal electric field sampled at the interface is

$$E_n = \mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{n} = \frac{E_r - R_z E_z}{\sqrt{1 + R_z^2}}. \quad (44)$$

The axisymmetric curvature of the surface of revolution is

$$\kappa = \frac{1}{R\sqrt{1+R_z^2}} - \frac{R_{zz}}{(1+R_z^2)^{3/2}}. \quad (45)$$

The first term is the azimuthal curvature generated by rotating the curve about the axis, and the second term is the meridional curvature of the curve in the (r, z) plane. This expression is used directly in the residual computation.

4.9 Young–Laplace–Maxwell Residual

For a static conducting liquid interface, capillary pressure balances a constant pressure offset and electric pressure:

$$\gamma\kappa = \Delta p + \frac{\varepsilon_0}{2} E_n^2. \quad (46)$$

Rearranging gives the pointwise residual

$$\mathcal{R}(z) = \gamma\kappa(z) - \Delta p - \frac{\varepsilon_0}{2} E_n(z)^2. \quad (47)$$

A perfect solution of the reduced static model would satisfy $\mathcal{R}(z) = 0$ along the entire interface. In practice, the solver evaluates a candidate interface and reports the RMS residual

$$\mathcal{R}_{\text{RMS}} = \left(\frac{1}{N} \sum_{m=1}^N \mathcal{R}(z_m)^2 \right)^{1/2}. \quad (48)$$

Since Δp is an unknown constant pressure offset, the implementation removes its mean contribution by choosing

$$\Delta p = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{m=1}^N \left(\gamma\kappa(z_m) - \frac{\varepsilon_0}{2} E_n(z_m)^2 \right). \quad (49)$$

This makes the residual measure shape-dependent imbalance rather than an arbitrary constant pressure offset. The residual is therefore a diagnostic of physical balance, not merely a numerical iteration error.

4.10 Reduced Shape Optimization

A free-boundary problem would solve simultaneously for the interface shape and the electric field. The current solver uses a lower-dimensional approximation: the interface is restricted to an analytic cone-family shape with a small number of shape parameters, such as half-angle and apex radius. The optimizer minimizes an objective of the form

$$J(\mathbf{a}) = \mathcal{R}_{\text{RMS}}(\mathbf{a}) + \lambda P(\mathbf{a}), \quad (50)$$

where $\mathbf{a}$ denotes shape parameters and P penalizes invalid or off-grid geometries if needed. This formulation keeps the problem computationally light and interpretable. Its limitation is that grid-mask boundary representation can shift the optimized angle away from the ideal Taylor value, which is why the optimized-angle error is treated as a known numerical limitation.

4.11 Effective Space-Charge Shielding

Poisson's equation requires a closure for ρ_e . The project uses a hierarchy of effective closures rather than claiming a complete microscopic emission model. The Gaussian closure is

$$\rho_e(r, z) = \rho_0 \exp \left[-\frac{(r - r_a)^2 + (z - z_a)^2}{2\ell^2} \right], \quad (51)$$

where (r_a, z_a) is the charge-cloud center and ℓ is the cloud width. This closure is useful for controlled numerical experiments because the location, sign, and magnitude of charge are explicit.

The threshold closure activates charge only in high-field regions:

$$\rho_e = \rho_{\max} \left[1 - \exp \left(-\frac{|\mathbf{E}| - E_c}{E_s} \right) \right]_+, \quad (52)$$

where E_c is a critical field scale, E_s controls smoothness, and $\rho_{\max}$ is a saturation density. The notation $[x]_+ = \max(x, 0)$ ensures that nodes with $|\mathbf{E}| < E_c$ produce zero effective charge.

Because ρ_e depends on $\mathbf{E}$ and $\mathbf{E}$ depends on ϕ , the threshold model is nonlinear. The solver uses fixed-point iteration:

$$\nabla^2 \phi^{(k+1)} = -\rho_e^{(k)} / \varepsilon_0, \quad (53)$$

$$\mathbf{E}^{(k+1)} = -\nabla \phi^{(k+1)}, \quad (54)$$

$$\tilde{\rho}_e^{(k+1)} = F(|\mathbf{E}^{(k+1)}|), \quad (55)$$

$$\rho_e^{(k+1)} = (1 - \omega)\rho_e^{(k)} + \omega\tilde{\rho}_e^{(k+1)}, \quad (56)$$

where $0 < \omega \leq 1$ is an under-relaxation parameter. The iteration stops when the relative change in ρ_e is below a prescribed tolerance or when a maximum iteration count is reached.

4.12 Shielding Metric

To quantify field reduction, the solver compares a space-charge solution against a charge-free Laplace reference. A local region-of-interest metric is

$$S_E = 1 - \frac{\max_{\Omega_{\text{ROI}}} |\mathbf{E}_{\text{shielded}}|}{\max_{\Omega_{\text{ROI}}} |\mathbf{E}_{\text{Laplace}}|}. \quad (57)$$

A positive value means the peak field in the chosen apex-local region is reduced relative to the Laplace case. A negative value indicates either field enhancement, sign sensitivity, or that the chosen region is dominated by boundary artifacts. The region of interest is important because global peak fields may occur at electrode corners or artificial computational boundaries rather than at the cone apex.

4.13 Nondimensional Interpretation

Let L be a characteristic length scale and V_0 the applied voltage scale. Define

$$\hat{r} = \frac{r}{L}, \quad \hat{z} = \frac{z}{L}, \quad \hat{\phi} = \frac{\phi}{V_0}. \quad (58)$$

The electric field scale is

$$E_0 = \frac{V_0}{L}. \quad (59)$$

The electric pressure scale is

$$p_{E,0} = \varepsilon_0 \frac{V_0^2}{L^2}, \quad (60)$$

while the capillary pressure scale is

$$p_{\gamma,0} = \frac{\gamma}{L}. \quad (61)$$

Their ratio is the electric Bond number

$$Bo_E = \frac{\varepsilon_0 V_0^2}{\gamma L}. \quad (62)$$

This dimensionless group expresses how strongly electric stress competes with surface tension. Increasing voltage raises Bo_E , while increasing surface tension lowers it. This relationship motivates experimental onset-voltage trends: larger surface tension or larger characteristic length scale generally requires higher voltage for comparable electric-capillary balance, although real electrospray onset also depends on conductivity, flow, electrode shape, and emission physics.

A dimensionless charge density can be defined as

$$\hat{\rho}_e = \frac{L^2 \rho_e}{\varepsilon_0 V_0}, \quad (63)$$

so the nondimensional Poisson equation becomes

$$\hat{\nabla}^2 \hat{\phi} = -\hat{\rho}_e. \quad (64)$$

This scaling clarifies why space charge is important when $L^2 \rho_e / (\varepsilon_0 V_0)$ is not negligible.

4.14 Model-Based Onset Criterion

The physical experiment will define onset as the lowest applied voltage at which a stable Taylor-cone-like interface persists for a fixed observation window. A simulation cannot observe stability directly unless it includes time-dependent fluid dynamics, so the solver must use a reduced static criterion. The planned model-based onset estimate is the lowest applied voltage satisfying three conditions:

1. the residual-minimizing interface is Taylor-cone-like and remains inside the computational geometry;
2. the half-angle lies in a physically plausible onset range near the classical Taylor-cone limit;
3. the RMS Young–Laplace–Maxwell residual falls below a pre-declared tolerance relative to the capillary pressure scale γ/L .

Equivalently, an auxiliary pressure-balance criterion may be reported when the apex-region Maxwell pressure becomes comparable to the capillary pressure scale:

$$\frac{\varepsilon_0 E_{n,\text{apex}}^2 / 2}{\gamma / L} = O(1). \quad (65)$$

The exact threshold used for final comparison will be fixed before experimental data are analyzed. This prevents tuning the numerical onset criterion after seeing the measurements.

4.15 Summary of Theoretical Deliverables

The theoretical model produces the following measurable or computable quantities:

- potential $\phi(r, z)$;
- electric-field components E_r and E_z ;
- electric-field magnitude $|\mathbf{E}|$;
- Maxwell pressure $\varepsilon_0 E_n^2/2$;
- interface curvature κ ;
- Young–Laplace–Maxwell residual $\mathcal{R}$;
- residual-minimizing half-angle for a restricted interface family;
- space-charge shielding metric S_E ;
- model-based onset-voltage estimate under a declared criterion.

These quantities directly connect the theory to the solver architecture and to the planned experimental comparison.

5 Solver Architecture

5.1 Implementation Overview

The solver is implemented as a modular Python package. Its main modules are summarized in Table 1. The design goal is to keep the numerical core transparent and testable while using sparse linear algebra for consumer-hardware feasibility.

Table 1: Main solver modules.

Module	Responsibility
<code>grid.py</code>	Axisymmetric grid and indexing convention
<code>operators.py</code>	Sparse Laplace/Poisson finite-difference operator
<code>boundary_conditions.py</code>	Dirichlet boundary insertion
<code>electrostatics.py</code>	Laplace/Poisson solve entry points
<code>fields.py</code>	Electric-field reconstruction and interpolation
<code>interface.py</code>	Interface geometry, curvature, half-angle extraction
<code>residual.py</code>	Young–Laplace–Maxwell residual diagnostics
<code>space_charge.py</code>	Gaussian and threshold space-charge closures
<code>optimization.py</code>	Low-dimensional cone-family shape optimization
<code>app_backend.py</code>	Streamlit-independent backend for interactive app

5.2 Computational Pipeline

A typical solver run follows this sequence:

1. Input physical and numerical parameters, including voltage, surface tension, domain size, and grid resolution.
2. Build a two-dimensional axisymmetric (r, z) grid.
3. Construct electrode and boundary masks.
4. Assemble the sparse axisymmetric Laplace/Poisson matrix.
5. Apply boundary conditions and solve $A\phi = \mathbf{b}$.

6. Reconstruct E_r , E_z , and $|\mathbf{E}|$.
7. Sample a candidate interface $R(z)$.
8. Compute interface normals, curvature, Maxwell pressure, capillary pressure, and residual.
9. Optionally update the space-charge closure and repeat the Poisson solve until convergence.
10. Return diagnostics, plots, and exported arrays.

5.3 Consumer-Hardware Design

The solver uses sparse matrices rather than dense matrices. For a grid of $n_r \times n_z$ nodes, the number of unknowns scales as $n_r n_z$, while the finite-difference operator has only a small number of nonzero stencil entries per row. This allows small-to-moderate grids to run quickly on a standard laptop. Runtime and memory scaling will be quantified as part of the final validation package.

5.4 Interactive App

The repository includes a Streamlit application that exposes basic parameters such as voltage, surface tension, electrode spacing, domain radius, grid resolution, and space-charge model. It returns scalar diagnostics and Plotly visualizations of potential, electric-field magnitude, space-charge density, interface overlay, and residual profile. The app is a demonstration and analysis interface; the scientific contribution remains the solver and validation workflow.

6 Current Numerical Validation

The repository currently contains automated tests and numerical examples that verify the solver independently of future experiments. These results establish that the computational core is functioning before experimental validation is attempted.

6.1 Automated Tests

The current test suite passes all available tests:

33 passed.

The tests cover grid indexing, sparse operator assembly, axis regularity stencils, boundary conditions, Poisson sign convention, electric-field reconstruction, interpolation, curvature, residual behavior, Taylor-angle benchmark, space-charge closures, optimization sanity checks, and app-backend outputs.

6.2 Classical Taylor-Angle Benchmark

The analytical benchmark routine computes

$$\alpha_T = 49.290\,089\,292\,1^\circ,$$

matching the classical Taylor half-angle. This confirms that the theoretical benchmark is correctly represented in code.

6.3 Manufactured Poisson Convergence

A manufactured solution is used to verify the Poisson solver:

$$\phi(r, z) = r^4 + z^4 + r^2 z^2. \quad (66)$$

For this function,

$$\nabla^2 \phi = 18r^2 + 16z^2. \quad (67)$$

The existing convergence data are shown in Table 2.

Table 2: Manufactured Poisson convergence results from the current solver report.

Grid	L2 error	Linf error	Nonzeros	Solve time (s)
25×27	8.104×10^{-4}	1.353×10^{-3}	3050	0.0010
49×53	1.992×10^{-4}	3.389×10^{-4}	12338	0.0027
97×105	4.936×10^{-5}	8.479×10^{-5}	49634	0.0134

The decreasing error under refinement supports correctness of the finite-difference discretization.

6.4 Voltage Scaling

In a parallel-plate Laplace case, doubling voltage from 500 V to 1000 V produces an electric-field ratio of approximately 2 and an implied Maxwell-pressure ratio of approximately 4. This agrees with $|\mathbf{E}| \propto V$ and $p_E \propto E^2$.

6.5 Residual Sanity Check

For a cylindrical interface with zero electric field, capillary pressure is constant and is removed by the mean pressure offset. The current numerical report gives an RMS residual of approximately

$$8.58 \times 10^{-16} \text{ Pa},$$

which is effectively numerical zero.

6.6 Known Optimizer Limitation

The current cone-family shape optimizer recovers an optimized half-angle near 43.5° in one demonstration, compared with the ideal 49.3° Taylor limit. This deviation is attributed to the grid-mask representation of the conical conductor rather than a sharp immersed boundary. This limitation will be handled by either improving the boundary representation or explicitly quantifying angle error versus grid resolution.

7 Planned Experimental Methodology

7.1 Purpose

The experimental component will validate observable Taylor-cone quantities predicted by the solver. The goal is not to demonstrate a propulsion device or characterize full cone-jet breakup. Instead, the experiment will measure onset-level geometry and voltage trends for comparison with the reduced-order model.

7.2 Experimental Observables

The planned primary observables are:

- cone half-angle measured from images,
- interface profile coordinates extracted from silhouettes,
- onset voltage for stable Taylor-cone formation,
- qualitative regime classification: no cone, unstable deformation, stable cone, or spray onset,
- repeatability across trials.

7.3 Controlled and Recorded Variables

The experiment will record electrode spacing, needle or nozzle geometry, liquid identity, surface tension or literature surface-tension value, conductivity or dopant condition, applied voltage, flow rate, camera calibration scale, frame rate, temperature, humidity if available, and trial notes. A metadata template will be prepared before data collection to ensure repeatability.

7.4 Experimental Design

The planned validation experiment uses a supervised electrospray/Taylor-cone imaging setup. A conductive or doped liquid will be delivered at controlled low flow rate to a needle/nozzle facing a grounded extractor electrode. A camera and backlight will record the meniscus silhouette near onset. Voltage will be varied under supervision until a stable Taylor-cone-like shape is observed. The stable frame sequence will be analyzed with the image-processing pipeline described in Section 8.

Primary validation should begin with one carefully controlled geometry and one low-flow operating condition, repeated several times. Additional trials may vary electrode spacing, voltage, or flow condition to test trends. Because the present solver is primarily electrostatic-capillary and static, flow-rate-dependent conclusions will be treated cautiously unless additional flow physics is added.

7.5 Planned Trial Matrix

A preliminary trial matrix is shown in Table 3. Values will be finalized after approval and equipment availability are confirmed.

Table 3: Draft experimental trial matrix. Exact values will be finalized before supervised testing.

Variable	Primary setting	Secondary sweep	Purpose
Electrode spacing	Fixed baseline	2–3 spacings	Onset-voltage trend
Flow rate	One low-flow baseline	Optional low-flow sweep	Repeatability/robustness
Voltage	Ramp to onset	Repeated trials	Onset threshold
Fluid condition	One characterized fluid	Optional conductivity variation	Model sensitivity

7.6 Definition of Experimental Onset

The experimental onset voltage will be defined operationally as the lowest applied voltage at which a stable Taylor-cone-like interface persists for a specified observation window without immediate collapse or uncontrolled breakup. The final observation-window length and stability criteria will be fixed before data collection to reduce subjective bias.

7.7 Definition of Simulated Onset

The simulated onset voltage requires a formal numerical criterion. The planned criterion is to sweep applied voltage and identify the lowest voltage for which a Taylor-cone-like candidate interface satisfies a pre-defined residual threshold and physically reasonable half-angle range. An alternative or secondary criterion is the voltage at which apex-region Maxwell pressure becomes comparable to capillary pressure. The final criterion will be selected and documented before comparison with experimental onset data.

8 Image Processing and Comparison Method

8.1 Computer-Vision Pipeline

The image-processing pipeline will convert recorded Taylor-cone images into quantitative interface coordinates. The planned workflow is:

1. select stable frames from video sequences,
2. crop the region of interest around the meniscus,
3. calibrate pixels to physical length using a known needle/nozzle dimension or calibration target,
4. apply thresholding and/or edge detection,
5. extract the cone boundary contour,
6. fit local interface slopes near the cone region,
7. compute the experimental half-angle,
8. export $(r_{\text{exp}}, z_{\text{exp}})$ profile coordinates and uncertainty estimates.

Before physical data are collected, the pipeline will be tested on synthetic cone images with known ground-truth angles. This will validate that the angle-extraction method can recover known geometry under blur, noise, and thresholding variation.

8.2 Profile Alignment

Simulation and experiment will be compared in the same coordinate system. Experimental pixel coordinates will be converted to millimeters and aligned so that the extracted apex or another reproducible reference point matches the simulation coordinate origin. The experimental radius $r_{\text{exp}}(z_i)$ will be interpolated onto the simulation z_i locations, or both profiles will be interpolated onto a common coordinate grid.

8.3 Validation Metrics

The primary profile metric will be the root mean square error:

$$\text{RMSE}_R = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N (R_{\text{sim}}(z_i) - R_{\text{exp}}(z_i))^2}. \quad (68)$$

A normalized version will divide by a characteristic length L_c , such as electrode spacing or observed cone length:

$$\text{nRMSE}_R = \frac{\text{RMSE}_R}{L_c}. \quad (69)$$

The cone-angle error will be

$$\Delta\alpha = |\alpha_{\text{sim}} - \alpha_{\text{exp}}|. \quad (70)$$

For onset voltage,

$$\epsilon_V = \frac{|V_{\text{sim}} - V_{\text{exp}}|}{V_{\text{exp}}}. \quad (71)$$

Repeated trials will report mean, standard deviation, and uncertainty intervals where possible.

8.4 Planned Output Figures

The final paper will include: raw image frames, detected-edge overlays, extracted cone profiles, simulated-versus-experimental profile overlays, half-angle comparison plots, onset-voltage comparison plots, and runtime scaling figures.

9 Expected Results and Experimental Placeholders

The current submission draft is prepared before physical experiments have been completed. Therefore, experimental result locations are explicitly marked as placeholders rather than fabricated or assumed data.

9.1 Computational Results Already Available

Current completed computational results include:

- classical Taylor half-angle benchmark: $49.290\,089\,292\,1^\circ$,
- manufactured Poisson convergence under grid refinement,
- voltage scaling check showing $E \propto V$ and $p_E \propto V^2$,
- residual null sanity check with near-zero RMS residual,
- Gaussian and threshold space-charge closure demonstrations,
- automated test suite passing all current tests.

9.2 Experimental Tables to Complete

Table 4: Placeholder for experimental half-angle comparison.

Trial	V_{exp}	α_{exp}	α_{sim}	$\Delta\alpha$
1	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
2	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
3	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD

Table 5: Placeholder for interface-profile and onset-voltage validation.

Condition	Profile RMSE	nRMSE	V_{exp}	ϵ_V
Baseline	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
Spacing sweep 1	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD
Spacing sweep 2	TBD	TBD	TBD	TBD

9.3 Criteria for Interpreting Agreement

Agreement will not be treated as binary proof. Instead, the project will report quantitative error and compare it with experimental uncertainty and model assumptions. Strong agreement would mean small angle error, low normalized profile RMSE, and correct onset-voltage trends across controlled geometry changes. Disagreement will be analyzed to identify whether the dominant cause is experimental uncertainty, finite-grid geometry, simplified space-charge closure, or missing physics.

10 Safety, Ethics, and Compliance

The project contains a computational component and a proposed experimental validation component. The computational component can proceed independently. The physical experiment will not begin until appropriate school approval, local scientific review, risk assessment, and qualified adult supervision are secured.

The proposed experimental validation may involve high voltage and flammable solvent, so it must be treated as a hazardous-device and hazardous-chemical activity. Before purchasing, assembling, or operating any apparatus, the project team will prepare required approval forms, a full risk assessment, safety data sheet documentation, supervision plan, schematic review, operating boundaries, and emergency shutoff procedures. Operation will occur only in a supervised school or laboratory environment, with appropriate enclosure, interlock, current limiting, grounding, ventilation, PPE, and waste-disposal procedures as required by school and competition rules.

No live high-voltage demonstration is planned for a public fair setting. Experimental data, images, videos, and analysis results will be presented instead. The apparatus is intended for microfluidic Taylor-cone observation and image-based validation, not as a projectile device or propulsion demonstration. The project will comply with all applicable Hong Kong selection-fair and Regeneron ISEF-affiliated rules.

11 Limitations

The present solver is intentionally reduced-order. It does not solve full transient Navier–Stokes equations, full Taylor–Melcher leaky-dielectric surface charge conservation, droplet breakup, plume dynamics, or complete thruster performance. The effective space-charge closures are phenomenological models for studying Poisson shielding trends, not predictive emitted-current laws.

The axisymmetric assumption is appropriate for onset-level symmetric geometries but may fail after non-axisymmetric instabilities or downstream jet breakup appear. The finite-difference grid representation introduces geometric error, especially near sharp conical interfaces. The current optimizer-angle deviation from the ideal Taylor half-angle highlights this limitation and motivates improved boundary treatment or explicit grid-convergence quantification.

Experimental validation will also have limitations. Cone-angle extraction depends on image resolution, optical alignment, lighting, threshold selection, calibration accuracy, and frame selection. Onset voltage may depend on fluid impurities, humidity, flow stability, electrode condition, and subjective stability criteria unless carefully standardized. Therefore, final conclusions will be stated in terms of quantified agreement and uncertainty rather than exact prediction.

12 Conclusion and Future Work

This project develops a lightweight sparse Python solver for onset-level Taylor-cone modeling. The current codebase already includes an axisymmetric electrostatic solver, field reconstruction, residual diagnostics, effective space-charge closures, a shape optimizer, a Streamlit app, automated tests, and numerical validation artifacts. It reproduces the classical Taylor half-angle benchmark and passes current numerical sanity checks.

The next stage is experimental validation. After required approval and supervision, Taylor-cone images will be collected, processed using computer vision, and compared against solver predictions using profile RMSE, angle error, onset-voltage error, and runtime metrics. This will test whether the reduced-order model is accurate enough for accessible early-stage parameter studies on consumer hardware.

Future work includes improving sharp-interface boundary representation, coupling threshold space charge inside the shape-optimization loop, adding more physically constrained charge/current closures, extending toward leaky-dielectric effects where justified, and comparing against higher-fidelity simulations or published experimental datasets. The intended contribution is not to replace full multiphysics simulation, but to provide a transparent, reproducible, and computationally accessible model for Taylor-cone onset studies.

References

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A Submission Checklist

Before final submission, the following items should be completed:

- Confirm official Hong Kong selection-fair formatting requirements.
- Replace placeholder author/school information.
- Confirm word/page limits and adjust length if needed.
- Add final experimental figures and tables after approved data collection.
- Add uncertainty estimates and repeated-trial statistics.
- Confirm that all safety approvals are documented before experimental work.
- Clean repository paths and ensure reproducible commands are correct.
- Verify all citations and bibliography formatting.
- Compile final PDF and check figures, tables, hyperlinks, and equation numbering.

B Reproducibility Notes

The solver repository is organized so that numerical results can be reproduced from the project root. The current local path is:

```
/Users/a1/Desktop/isef
```

The Python environment used during this draft is Miniforge Python:

```
/Users/a1/miniforge3/bin/python
```

Important commands are:

```
/Users/a1/miniforge3/bin/python -m pytest -q  
/Users/a1/miniforge3/bin/python examples/04_taylor_angle_benchmark.py  
/Users/a1/miniforge3/bin/python examples/05_shape_optimization_demo.py  
/Users/a1/miniforge3/bin/python -m streamlit run app/streamlit_app.py
```

The final repository should include scripts for exporting simulation profiles, processing experimental images, and generating comparison figures.